sacred tirthas (river-bank cities): Prayagraj, Haridwar, Ujjain and Nasik. Attendees also include ascetics (Naga Sadhus), some of them militant ascetics, who are devoted Shiva worshippers. Tradition has it that it was them who controlled and managed the Mela until 1801 and would fight for the privilege of taking the first snan, which conferred upon them power and status. Even today, visuals of ash-covered Naga sadhus and other members of the Juna Akhara, the largest monastic order racing down the banks into the water carrying tridents are a common sight. Also common are visuals of tens of thousands of ascetics, some dressed in saffron robes, some nude and covered with ash, with wild dreadlocks riding on horseback, or in golden seats on elephants. Conch blowing, gong beating and loud drumming usually accompany this dramatic entry of the akharas.

The new Uttarakhand chief minister Tirath Singh Rawat decided not to cancel the event despite the raging pandemic and proceed with a shorter, less attended one. The Uttarakhand government was confident that it would be able to manage reduced crowds and ensure that COVID-19-appropriate protocols were followed. For this, it had deployed about 15,000 police personnel, several CCTV cameras and drones for surveillance. Sanitizer stalls and hygienic changing rooms which would undergo regular sanitization were installed as well. All travellers entering the Mela were required to upload a negative RT-PCR test taken up to 72 hours prior in order to get an entry pass. The time of snan was also limited to one and a half hour for each akhara. However, despite their best preparations, the waves of people arriving were too overwhelming for the government to ensure that COVID-19 protocol was followed. Within days, the city of Haridwar and neighbouring areas became COVID-19 hot spots with a surge of cases. Seven Hindu saints and over 300 pilgrims tested COVID-19 positive within a week of the beginning of the festival.

Pictures of huge crowds immersing themselves into the river for the shahi snan took over television news channels, front-page stories and social media. Several people began to question as to why the festival was allowed to take place at all. As much as it is within the rights of citizens to ask this question, the fact is that cancelling a huge religious gathering, which is a matter of utmost faith in several religious groups, is easier said than done. Just a few weeks later, a revered seer Swami Avdheshanand Giri Maharaj, in an article, emotionally expressed his frustration with the narrative. He said,